Foreword

Food connects us to the land, to the water, and to each other. This cookbook is published as part of the International Year of the Woman Farmer and the International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists, two global observances that invite us to look more closely at who grows, raises, catches, processes and prepares the food we eat, and to recognize the contributions of women across agrifood systems.

Across every continent, women are custodians of seeds and soils, herders and milk processors, fishers and fish traders, cooks and knowledge-keepers. They manage rangelands, tend crops, harvest from rivers and seas, and pass down techniques refined over generations. Their work underpins food security, nutrition and the resilience of rural communities, yet it remains frequently invisible, undervalued and underpaid. Despite their important contributions to agrifood systems, women are often underrepresented in decision-making.

This collection brings together recipes and stories from women and women's groups working across land, pasture and water systems in every region of the world. Each dish offers a window into a livelihood, a landscape and a set of relationships: between people and animals, people and plants, and people and each other.

We hope this cookbook will be read, cooked from and shared. It is offered both as a celebration and as an invitation to continue building food systems shaped by the women who sustain them.

Tacko Ndiaye
Gender Team Leader at the Rural Transformation
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International Year of the Woman Farmer

INTRODUCTION

Across the world's farms, rangelands, rivers, lakes and coastlines, women are at work. They plant and harvest. They herd and process milk. They fish, farm fish and trade what they catch. They hold knowledge about seed varieties, grazing patterns and seasonal cycles that has been built over generations, often passed from mother to daughter.

The International Year of the Woman Farmer and the International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists offer an opportunity to recognize this work in its full breadth. Women are central to how agriculture, livestock-keeping and fisheries function, adapt and endure. They manage household food production and market-oriented enterprises. They are often among the first to notice environmental change and to adjust practices in response, frequently while facing unequal access to land, credit, training, markets and decision-making spaces.

WOMEN, FOOD SYSTEMS AND THE WORK OF FAO

Open the books at FAO and a simple fact comes into view: women are not a side note in agriculture, pastoralism and fisheries. They make up 41 percent of the agricultural workforce worldwide, and in many countries considerably more. They are the hands behind seed selection and crop care, the people who herd animals to water and back, the ones who gut, salt, smoke and sell the catch before it ever reaches a market stall. And yet, across nearly every measure, from land ownership to credit, training, wages and a seat at the table where decisions get made, women face a gap that men in the same roles do not.

This gap has a name in development circles: the gender gap in agrifood systems. It is well documented, persistent, and expensive. Closing it would not only change individual lives. It would strengthen food security, improve nutrition outcomes for whole households, and make rural economies more resilient to shocks, whether those shocks come from markets, conflict or a changing climate.

In 2026, two international observances put this gap, and the people working to close it, at the centre of the global conversation. The International Year of the Woman Farmer, designated by the United Nations General Assembly, spotlights the roles women play across the full span of agrifood value chains, from production and processing to trade and decision-making, and calls for policy reform and investment that turns recognition into measurable change. Alongside it, the International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists draws attention to the ecosystems that cover roughly half the Earth's land surface and to the estimated 1 billion animals herded across them by pastoralist communities present in more than three-quarters of the world's countries.

These two Years are connected by more than a shared calendar. Rangelands and pastoral systems are also food systems, and within them, as on cropland and at the water's edge, women's labour and knowledge are foundational, if frequently uncounted. A herder moving animals to fresh grazing, a processor turning milk into cheese that will keep through a dry season, a fish trader who knows exactly which buyer will pay fairly for today's catch: each is contributing to outcomes that matter for the Sustainable Development Goals on hunger, nutrition, gender equality, climate action and life on land and below water.

FAO's role across both observances is to convene, to coordinate with governments, producer organizations and UN partners, and to translate awareness into the kind of structural change that outlasts a single calendar year: secured access to land and resources, stronger extension and financial services, fairer value chains, and a stronger voice for women and pastoralist communities in the policies that affect them.

This cookbook sits inside that effort in a small but deliberate way. Every recipe in these pages is traceable to a place, a system and a woman or women's group whose work sustains it. Read together, they offer a kind of evidence: of skill, of adaptation, of knowledge passed down and put to use every day, in kitchens and on rangelands and at the water's edge, around the world.

ACROSS LAND, PASTURE AND WATER

This cookbook is organized around three systems in which women's work is central.

Land brings together stories of women farming staple crops, vegetables, legumes, grains and tree crops, from cassava and fonio to olives and rice, and of the cooperatives, field schools and seed-saving networks through which they organize and share knowledge.

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Pasture turns to rangelands and pastoral systems, where mobility, seasonality and close relationships with livestock shape both livelihoods and landscapes. Here, women's roles as herders, milk processors and holders of rangeland knowledge come into view, often in contexts where pastoralism itself is poorly understood by outside observers.

Water gathers stories from fisheries and aquaculture, freshwater and marine, inland and coastal, where women fish, farm fish, harvest shellfish and seaweed, process catches, and run the trading networks that move food from water to table.

Within each section, recipes and stories sit side by side, reflecting the reality that food, land, water and livelihoods are bound together.

WHY A COOKBOOK

A cookbook is an unusual format for a publication about agricultural policy and rural livelihoods, so it is worth explaining the choice.

The recipe here is a starting point, not the subject. Each dish in this collection is the visible result of work that often goes unseen: the seed selected and saved, the field tended through a season, the herd moved to new grazing, the catch brought in and processed, the knowledge of how to combine, ferment or preserve. A bowl of soup or a loaf of bread carries within it months of labour and decision-making that statistics struggle to convey.

There is a longer history here worth acknowledging. Cooking has always been more than provision. It is how communities maintain themselves, how knowledge circulates between generations, how people sustain the conditions that make everything else, including collective action, resilience to hardship, and the strength to keep going, possible. The women's cooperatives, field schools and community groups represented in this book know this. Food is not a byproduct of their work; it is the medium through which knowledge is shared, solidarity practised, and community held together.

By tracing each recipe back to the women and women's groups who grow, raise, catch or gather its ingredients, this cookbook offers a way into stories that might otherwise stay abstract. Food gives readers a shared point of reference across very different contexts, from high-altitude pastures to mangrove coastlines, from rice terraces to reindeer camps.

HOW THIS COOKBOOK WAS MADE

Each recipe in this collection is paired with a story about a woman, a family or a women's group, told in their own context and, where possible, in their own words. These stories were gathered through partnerships with local organizations, cooperatives, field schools and community groups, with care taken to represent each contributor's work and knowledge accurately.

The recipes have been tested and adapted for a global kitchen by our cookbook author, a cook, teacher and recipe writer, working closely with the person who shared each recipe – who is not always the woman or group featured in the accompanying story – to preserve its local ingredients, techniques and traditions, alongside the context needed to understand where it comes from.

HOW TO USE **THIS BOOK**

This cookbook is organized into three sections: Land, Pasture and Water, reflecting the systems introduced above. Within each section, recipes are arranged by country, moving across regions to give a sense of the breadth and diversity of women's work in agriculture, pastoralism and fisheries worldwide.

Each recipe begins with a story: about a woman or a women's group, their work, and the landscape, livestock or waters they depend on. The recipe itself follows, adapted for cooks anywhere while staying true to its origins. Together, the story and the recipe are meant to be read as one, the dish as an outcome of the work described.

At the back of the book, an extended acknowledgements section lists, recipe by recipe, the individuals, cooperatives, projects and partner organizations who contributed to each story and recipe. Readers wishing to learn more, or to support this work directly, are encouraged to start there.

LAND

Start with a seed. Somewhere behind every dish in this section is a decision about which seed to plant, made long before any pot reached the stove. In the highlands of Ecuador, in the cassava fields of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, in olive groves and rice paddies and millet fields across Africa, Asia, the Caucasus and the Pacific, that decision has, for generations, fallen disproportionately to women.

Land brings together stories of women growing the staple crops, vegetables, legumes, grains and tree crops that anchor diets and economies: cassava, fonio, teff, rice, beans, moringa, olives, taro, fava beans, herbs and honey. Some of these crops are ancient, cultivated for millennia in forms barely changed. Others are being adapted in real time, as farmers experiment with new varieties, new techniques and new ways of organizing their work to cope with shifting rainfall, degraded soils and volatile markets.

What runs through these stories is not only cultivation but stewardship. Many of the women featured here are not working alone. They are members of cooperatives that pool land, labour, equipment and risk. They are graduates of farmer field schools, where new techniques are tested on a small plot before being adopted more widely. They are custodians of agrobiodiversity, the often-overlooked variety of crop types and varieties that keeps food systems flexible in the face of pests, disease and climate stress. A single woman's choice to keep growing an old variety of bean or grain, even as markets push towards a handful of commercial varieties, can matter for food systems far beyond her own field.

Access remains the throughline. Across the countries represented in this section, women farmers are less likely than men to hold formal title to the land they work, less likely to access credit on the same terms, and less likely to receive the extension services and training that would let them adopt new techniques more quickly. The recipes that follow are a way of seeing past those statistics to the work itself: the planting, the weeding, the harvesting, the saving of seed for next season, and the cooking that turns all of it into a meal.

PASTURE

Rangelands do not look like farmland, and pastoralism does not look like farming, at least not at first glance. There are no neat rows, no fixed plots, and often there are no fences at all. What there is, instead, is movement: herds following grass and water across seasons, sometimes across borders, in patterns refined over centuries to match the rhythms of land that could not sustain settled agriculture in any other way.

Rangelands cover roughly half of the Earth's land surface, spanning grasslands, savannas, shrublands, deserts, wetlands and high mountain pastures. Pastoralist communities, present in more than three-quarters of the world's countries, manage an estimated 1 billion animals across these landscapes, turning vegetation that humans cannot eat into milk, meat and other foods that sustain millions of people. In doing so, they also maintain ecosystems that store carbon, regulate water and support biodiversity found nowhere else.

Within pastoralist communities, women's roles are the least visible, although they often carry heavier workloads due to high levels of unpaid and invisible work. In many cases, women milk the animals, process that milk into butter, cheese, yoghurt or other products that can be stored, traded or carried on the move. They hold detailed knowledge of which plants are good medicinal plants, how a herd's condition reflects the health of the land it has grazed, and hold important ethnoveterinary knowledge that they pass on to future generations.

The stories in this section, from high mountain pastures to Arctic reindeer-herding communities, from East African rangelands to the Arabian Peninsula, are united less by geography than by this shared relationship between people, animals and land. Mobility, often viewed from outside as a problem to be solved, is in fact the mechanism that makes these systems work: it is how pastoralists avoid overgrazing any single area, how herds find fresh pasture as seasons change, and how communities adapt to a climate that is, in many of these regions, becoming harder to predict. Recognizing women's role within these systems means recognizing pastoralism itself, on its own terms, as a sophisticated and adaptive way of producing food.

WATER

Fish does not wait. From the moment it leaves the water, a clock starts running, and what happens in the hours that follow, who cleans it, salts it, smokes it, dries it, carries it to market, sells it, often determines whether a catch becomes income and food or becomes waste. Across the freshwater and marine fisheries represented in this section, that work, the work that happens after the catch, is overwhelmingly done by women.

Water gathers stories from inland rivers and lakes, from mangrove coastlines and open ocean, from the Amazon basin to the Pacific islands, from West Africa to East Asia and the Middle East. Some of the women featured here fish themselves, diving or wading for shellfish and seaweed in traditions passed down through generations. Others farm fish in ponds and cages, harvest oysters from mangrove shallows, or run the small-scale processing and trading operations that move fish from boat to plate, often across considerable distances and through informal networks built on trust and reputation.

Fish and aquatic foods are a major source of animal protein and essential micronutrients for billions of people, particularly in coastal and riverine communities where alternatives may be limited or costly. Aquaculture now supplies over half of the fish consumed globally, easing some pressure on wild stocks alongside continued efforts towards sustainability and equitable access. In both capture fisheries and aquaculture, women's contributions – as fishers, farmers, processors and traders – are essential to how food moves from water to table, even though women are frequently underrepresented in the data, in fisheries management bodies, and in the policies that govern access to fishing grounds and water resources.

Part of the reason women's work in fisheries remains undercounted is that so much of it happens after the boat comes in. Gutting, salting, smoking, drying, fermenting, packing and selling are not glamorous tasks, and they take place at the margins of what tends to be measured and valued in fisheries statistics. But without this work, a catch does not become food. It is skilled, time-consuming and often physically demanding, and it is the step that determines whether a family has income that week, whether a community has protein through a lean season, and whether traditional preservation techniques survive to the next generation.

The recipes in this section reflect what is done with fish and other aquatic foods once they reach a kitchen: stewed, dried, fermented, smoked, curried, wrapped in leaves, served raw. Behind each dish is a longer chain of decisions and labour, about where to fish, how to process a catch before it spoils, and how to get it to someone willing to buy it. Seeing that chain is part of what this section offers.

CONCLUSION

The recipes and stories gathered in this collection span continents, climates and culinary traditions, from herb-filled pastries in Azerbaijan to smoked reindeer in Norway, from oyster harvests on the Gambian coast to seaweed curries in the United Republic of Tanzania. What connects them is a simple truth: in every one of these places, women's knowledge and labour are central to how food reaches the table.

Published as part of the International Year of the Woman Farmer and the International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists, this cookbook celebrates that contribution across land, where women farm staple crops, manage agrobiodiversity and lead cooperatives; across pasture, where women herd livestock, process milk and hold deep knowledge of rangeland systems; and across water, where women fish, farm fish, harvest, process and trade.

These two International Years call on governments, organizations and communities to strengthen the conditions under which women farmers and pastoralists work, improving access to land, resources, services, markets and decision-making. The stories in this cookbook put faces, names and places to that call, and are a reminder that the work behind every meal deserves recognition well beyond the kitchen.

Readers are invited to cook these recipes, share them, and carry their stories forward.

© Bruno Portier

And everyone – governments, institutions, communities and individuals alike – is invited to take up the spirit of these two International Years: to recognize and invest in the women whose work sustains food systems around the world.

For more information on the International Year of the Woman Farmer, the International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists, and related events and initiatives, please visit the official campaign pages.

Azerbaijan

AGE-OLD FARMING TRADITIONS IMPROVE WOMEN'S LIVES

Irada Asadova grew up in a small family farm and learned the value of hard work at an early age. After losing her husband, all the responsibilities fell on her shoulders, and she and her daughter worked tirelessly to develop the farm.

In Garakhanli village in Tovuz, she brought together a group of local women who cultivated potatoes and grain to form a collective. Using their harvest, they started producing flour and opened a small bakery, creating employment opportunities for several women.

The FAO project "Improved food security and rural livelihoods through women s economic empowerment" positively transformed the lives of Irada and her cooperative members, both socially and economically. By participating in FAO training programmes, they gained new knowledge and practical experience, including how to use modern irrigation systems. As a result, their work became easier, they saved water, and productivity increased.

Today, as the first woman-led cooperative group operating in the region, Irada and her group are expanding their activities, increasing production, and exploring new areas of work.

Their cooperative cultivates potatoes and grain crops, continuing a farming tradition passed down through generations. Potatoes are grown both for local consumption and for commercial markets, providing one of the main sources of income for agricultural cooperatives such as Irada's.

Fortunately, the cooperative faces no major environmental challenges. The land is fertile, and the group consists of experienced and hardworking women farmers. However, the main challenge is preserving their harvest. During the hot summer months, potatoes and other agricultural products spoil quickly. Limited access to cold storage facilities and suitable warehouse facilities makes it difficult to store the harvest. To overcome this, the cooperative works to bring its products to market as quickly as possible.

Women farmers, beneficiaries of the Women Empowerment Project, stand together in a wheat field.

© FAO/Javid Gurbanov

AZERBAIJAN

QUTAB

GREEN HERB QUTAB

This recipe was passed down to the women in Irada's cooperative by their grandmothers. It is prepared by filling the dough with various herbs and greens and cooking it on a *saj*, a traditional metal cooking pan. The result is a delicious, nutritious and vitamin-rich traditional dish.

Qutab can be prepared throughout the year, but the women cook it more often in spring when fresh wild herbs are plentiful. The herbs used in its preparation are high in nutritional value for both children and adults. It is often specially prepared for guests and loved ones visiting from the city. It is both the centrepiece of the local table and a filling, healthy part of meals. In cities and towns, *qutab* is also a popular street food.

In winter, the ingredients are adapted to use those available during the season. The recipe mainly uses greenhouse-grown greens and vegetables such as spinach, coriander, dill, parsley and spring onions.

© Taliye Masimova

FOR
6+ QUTAB
YOU WILL NEED

- **1 kg** flour
- **3 g** yeast
- **1 tablespoon** of salt (heaping)
- **300 g** water
- **Mixed** greens/herbs (wild mountain coriander, cincilim – wild edible herbs/greens –, wild spinach, plantain leaf, mallow, coriander, dill, beet greens, spinach, green onions)
- **250 g** cheese
- **200 g** butter/oil

PREPARATION

First, the greens are carefully selected, cleaned and thoroughly washed with plenty of water. After washing, they are wrapped in a cloth to remove excess moisture and left to dry completely. This step is very important, as damp greens can affect the quality of the dough.

Meanwhile, the dough is prepared, kneading it until becomes soft and elastic. Divide it into small portions of approximately 150 g each, shape each portion into a ball, cover them, and leave them to rest.

Once the greens have dried, they are finely chopped. The cheese is either grated or finely chopped and mixed with the greens to prepare the filling.

The oven is preheated so that the baking process is even. The rested dough balls are rolled out into thin oval shapes. The prepared mixture of greens and cheese is then placed in the centre of each piece of rolled dough.

Then, the dough is folded over the filling and cooked on a *saj* or in the oven. It is baked until both sides turn golden brown.

Once cooked, the *qutab* are placed on a large tray and brushed with butter while still hot. This enhances their flavour, giving them a softer texture. Serve hot.

All photos: © Taliye Masimova

Democratic Republic of the Congo

TWO HARVESTS: HOW CASSAVA FEEDS FAMILIES TWICE

In the rolling hills around Mbanza-Ngungu, in Kongo-Central, women are often in their cassava fields before the sun is fully up. As their mothers and grandmothers did before them, they grow cassava (*Manihot esculenta*) for both harvests: the tubers that fill the family pot, and the tender young leaves they pick by hand, tied into bundles and carried to market, or pounded at home into *pondu* for the evening meal.

In recent years, the work has become less predictable. The rains do not come as they once did, and the soil does not always give back what it used to do. Still, the women continue to adapt, drawing on the knowledge handed down through generations. They stagger their planting, save what they can against a poor season, and read the land in the ways they were taught.

When money is needed – for school fees, seeds or the long trip to market – many turn to their village savings and credit associations. There, neighbours pool small amounts each week and lend to one another when the need arises. It is a community-led system, built on trust and sustained by women's commitment to supporting one another.

For the women of Mbanza-Ngungu, cassava feeds a family twice: once through its roots, and once through its leaves. And each time a mother pounds *pondu* with her daughter beside her, she passes on something else too: the recipe, the skill and the memory of how to keep going.

© Alice Adams Carosi

Mandefu Akwanza Dieudonné (left) and his workers harvest cassava in Bapukeli village, Okapi Wildlife Reserve, Democratic Republic of the Congo.

© FAO/Thomas Nicolon

DEMOCRATIC REPUBLIC OF THE CONGO

PONDU/SAKA-SAKA

CASSAVA LEAVES AND PALM OIL

This traditional Congolese recipe can be prepared in different ways. It can be served as a daily meal with rice or *fufu* (semolina), or as part of a meal for special occasions with a meat or fish stew. It is a recipe that has been passed down from generation to generation, from mother to daughter: an integral part of families' culinary heritage.

The names *pondu* and *saka saka* are virtually interchangeable. They are also used to describe the bright green-coloured paste of cooked and pounded cassava leaves, which are processed in order to be sold further afield.

© Alice Adams Carosi

TO FEED
4 PEOPLE
YOU WILL NEED

- **800 g** cassava leaves
- **2 cloves** of garlic, minced
- **1 medium-sized** onion, chopped
- **1 bell** pepper, roughly chopped
- **Handful of** chives or spring onions, chopped
- **1 eggplant,** diced
- **1 cup** ground peanuts
  (or 3 tablespoons peanut paste)
- **4 tablespoons** palm oil
- **Water**

PREPARATION

Remove the cassava leaves from the stalk. Boil them briefly (at least 15–20 minutes) in hot water to remove the cyanogenic compounds. Wash them thoroughly 2–3 times and drain well.

Clean the pestle and mortar. Put the leaves in the mortar and pound until you obtain a uniform green paste.

Add the garlic, onion, bell pepper, chives and eggplant. Mix while continuing to pound lightly. This is the *pondu* mix.

Put 2 tablespoons of palm oil into a cooking pot, add the *pondu* mix and a couple of pinches of salt.

Add 1 litre of water and cook over medium heat for 20–30 minutes.

Add the ground peanuts, another 2 tablespoons of palm oil and continue cooking for 30–45 minutes, until you obtain a creamy texture.

Stir to thoroughly incorporate the oil and peanuts.

Remove from heat and serve hot with rice or *fufu*. Add spring onions and/or peanuts to garnish (optional).

All photos: © FAO/Olivier Asselin

Ecuador

SEED GUARDIAN COMBATS CLIMATE CHANGE

Magdalena Laine is a farmer from the Kichwa Indigenous Peoples living in the Ecuadorian Andes. Together with her family, she farms heritage maize varieties at altitudes over 2 500 metres. Their farms are locally known as *chakra*, a biodiverse agricultural system recognized in 2023 by FAO as a Globally Important Agricultural Heritage System. In addition to nutrition, food security and income, *chakra* provide Kichwa People with medicine, fuel and fodder.

Every Sunday, Magdalena and her daughters rise early to participate in La Pachamama nos alimenta (Mother Earth feeds us), an agroecological market where some 300 Kichwa women gather weekly to sell their produce. At the market, Magdalena and her daughters sell fresh vegetables, grains and eggs, as well as maize flour and bags of native varieties of maize kernels.

Right after the harvest, Magdalena and her family store the varieties of maize and select the healthiest, cleanest kernels to be preserved for the next planting season. Her daughter Verónica calls her mother a "seed guardian": she preserves many native varieties of maize seeds, and teaches the younger generations the value of these seeds.

The plateaus of the Andes offer different altitudes and microclimate variations, and the local *chakra* hold the secrets to the large array of crops that Kichwa families produce and enjoy. However, extreme weather events related to climate change, like droughts and floods, are now threatening this system, with changing temperatures affecting the crops grown at given altitudes. These changes may also erode the knowledge that Kichwa women pass down to new generations, for instance when a certain crop needs to be planted.

With the financial and technical support of FAO, farmers' organizations like the Unión de Organizaciones Campesinas Indígenas

Magdalena Laine, a Kichwa farmer and seed guardian, holds heritage maize grown on her family's *chakra* in the Ecuadorian Andes.

de Cotacachi (UNORCAC) are implementing several initiatives to strengthen the climate resilience of Kichwa communities, for example diversifying food production through the use and exchange of native seeds.

Indeed, saving heritage grains is part of a strategy to transform the agrifood sector with a vision of inclusive rural development. Verónica is confident that the ancestral knowledge passed to her by her mother will help her – and future generations – overcome the challenges of climate change.

In this effort, women are key. According to Verónica, "women are the ones with the initiative… When I have my own family, I have to sow as my mother did, the same way she taught me. Everything she taught me will stay with me, and I should continue this wisdom."

All photos: © FAO Ecuador

ECUADOR

SOPA DE CHUCHUCA

TRADITIONAL ANDEAN CHUCHUCA SOUP

This traditional recipe is a true reflection of the *chakra* system. The protagonist of this dish is *chuchuca*, a partially matured maize that undergoes an ancestral preservation technique of sun-drying and milling. This recipe, shared by Magdalena Laine with the support of the UNORCAC Women's Committee, perfectly illustrates the nutritional wisdom of Andean women farmers. The dish combines the complex carbohydrates of preserved maize with the plant-based protein of fresh beans and the rich collagen of meat broth, creating a deeply nourishing and comforting meal that has fed generations.

© FAO Ecuador

© FAO Ecuador

Magdalena serves the traditional maize dish, cooked over an open fire in her home.

TO FEED **4-6 PEOPLE** YOU WILL NEED

- **450 g *chuchuca*** (sun-dried, semi-cooked Andean maize)
- **2 units** pork trotters (can be substituted with other pork or beef cuts for a rich broth)
- **3 cloves** garlic
- **1 medium** red onion
- **Approx. 450 g** of fresh beans
- **5 medium** potatoes
- **1 bunch** watercress
- **1 chopped** cabbage
- **1 carrot**
- **1 green** and **1** red bell pepper
- **1 pinch** salt (to taste)
- **225 g** *tostado* (traditional Andean toasted corn) for garnish

PREPARATION

To prepare the *chuchuca*, an ancestral maize preservation technique is applied. First, select mature, slightly starchy maize (locally known as *choclo cao*) and remove the kernels from the cob.

In a large pot, bring water to boil, add the corn kernels, and cook until they are tender.

Drain the kernels and spread them on a cloth under the sun to dry for 3 days, or until they are completely dehydrated.

Using a traditional hand mill, process the dried kernels to a medium texture (neither too fine nor too coarse) to ensure the perfect consistency for the soup. Store in portions for future use.

Thoroughly wash the required amount of ground *chuchuca* to ensure no small impurities remain.

To start cooking the *chuchuca* soup, in a large pot, bring water to a boil, add the clean *chuchuca*, and cook until it softens.

In a separate pot, cook the pork trotters with the cloves of garlic and half of the red onion until the meat is very tender.

To the main *chuchuca* pot, add the fresh tender beans, halved potatoes, and the watercress (and/or chopped cabbage).

Introduce the cooked pork trotters along with some of their rich cooking broth to deepen the flavour of the soup. Continue to simmer until the beans and potatoes are soft to the touch.

In a separate skillet, prepare a traditional *refrito* (soffritto base) by sautéing the finely diced carrot, the remaining half of the red onion, garlic and bell peppers. Stir this fragrant base into the simmering soup and cook for an additional 5 minutes to fuse the flavours. Adjust the salt to taste.

Serve the soup piping hot, accompanied by a generous handful of crunchy *tostado* on top.

Native maize kernels are poured into a clay pot over an open fire. (Top)

Maize cobs are husked and sorted by hand for preserving. (Bottom)

Magdalena raises freshly harvested maize in the field.

All photos: © FAO Ecuador

Egypt

THE FAVA BEAN: A STAPLE FOR EVERY TABLE

Fava beans *(Vicia faba)* are a traditional and well-established crop in many Egyptian provinces, and represent one of Egypt's most important legume staples. Aswan and Upper Egypt have been cultivating fava for generations. Like in other regions, fava are tied closely to local food culture.

Fava beans are mainly consumed as food, especially in common traditional forms such as *ful medames*, *ta'ameya* (Egyptian green falafel) and other home-cooked dishes. Many farming households traditionally keep part of the harvest for their own consumption throughout the year.

Fava also enable Egyptian women to turn food preparation into a livelihood: female entrepreneurship – highlighted as a regional priority – has seen many turn their *ta'ameya* making skills into micro-businesses, selling sandwiches in village markets or catering stalls.

Beyond food use, farmers traditionally value fava beans for their role in improving soil fertility and reducing the need for fertilizer in cereal-based rotations, which helps maintain soil productivity in the hot and dry conditions of Upper Egypt.

There are various environmental and economic challenges involved in fava bean cultivation. FAO farmer field schools help farmers to use practical climate-smart practices, including improved irrigation scheduling, weed management and regular field monitoring with integrated pest management.

At the farmer field schools, farmers engage in hands-on learning and experimentation throughout the season, which allows them to see tangible benefits. Thus, many farmers have adopted these practices on their own fields, and some have begun sharing knowledge and techniques with neighbours. This shows how farmer field schools can effectively transform traditional practices into more productive, resilient and sustainable systems.

All photos: © Ahmed Elshemy

A woman in Aswan presents freshly made *ta'ameya*, Egyptian fava bean falafel.

EGYPT

TA'AMEYA

GREEN FAVA BEAN PATTIES (EGYPTIAN FALAFEL)

Ta'ameya is a traditional Egyptian recipe made using fava beans, herbs and simple spices. In most families, the recipe is passed down from mother to daughter. Women learn it by helping in the kitchen from a young age – not from written recipes but through practice and memory, thus making the *ta'ameya* a special space for storytelling.

Ta'ameya is still very popular in both rural and urban areas today. What makes Egyptian *ta'ameya* special are the fava beans themselves, which give them a soft fluffy texture, and the use of abundant aromatic herbs that give them their distinctive green colour. If fava beans are not available, chickpeas can be used, but this changes the recipe into Levant-style falafels, which are different in taste, colour and texture.

© Ahmed Elshemy

FOR **20+**
TA'AMEYA
YOU WILL NEED

- **500 g** peeled dried fava beans (soaked overnight)
- **1 medium** onion or 1 cup chopped Egyptian leek (spring onion)
- **3–4 garlic** cloves
- **2–3 cups** of roughly chopped fresh coriander, parsley and dill (optional)
- **3 teaspoons** fine salt
- **1 teaspoon** black pepper
- **1 ½** tablespoons ground cumin
- **1 tablespoons** ground coriander
- **½ teaspoon** baking soda
- **1–2 eggs**
- **2 tablespoons** sesame seeds (optional)
- **Vegetable oil** for frying

NOTES: Soak the fava beans well, if possible overnight, to make them soft and easy to grind. There is no need to cook the beans for the mixture.

Grind the mixture very finely so that the *ta'ameya* will become light and fluffy. The oil to fry the *ta'ameya* should be hot, but not too hot, so that the *ta'ameya* cooks inside without burning outside. For a healthier option, *ta'ameya* can also be baked in the oven or cooked in an air fryer instead of fried.

PREPARATION

Rinse the dry fava beans well and soak them in water for 8 hours or overnight. Change the water every 2–4 hours if possible. In hot weather, keep the beans in the fridge while soaking.

Drain the beans. Add part of the beans to the food processor with chopped onion, garlic and herbs. Grind well. Since most food processors grind coarsely, transfer the mixture to a bowl and repeat in batches until all ingredients are processed. Combine everything and grind once more for a more even texture. If the mixture seems too dry, add a few tablespoons of water.

At this stage, you can divide the mixture into portions (about 1 cup each), place them in bags and freeze. When needed, thaw at room temperature.

Just before frying, add the eggs, ground coriander, salt, black pepper and baking soda. Mix by hand to get a smooth but not watery texture. Add sesame seeds now, or press each patty into sesame seeds before frying (optional).

Beat the batter well using your hands or a spoon, as this helps make the *ta'ameya* light and fluffy. If the mixture seems too wet, add some fava bean or chickpea flour.

Heat oil over medium-high heat. Using a wet tablespoon, scoop the batter and shape into flat patties. Keep your fingers wet so the mixture does non-stick. Drop carefully into the hot oil. When they start to turn golden, flip to cook evenly. Fry for about 3 minutes until crispy and cooked through. Do not let them burn.

Serve hot with flatbread, green salad, tahini and pickles (*torshi*).

All photos: © Ahmed Elshemy

Farmers harvest fava beans
in a field in Upper Egypt.

Freshly harvested fava
plants are gathered and
carried from the field.

All photos: © Ahmed Elshemy

Ethiopia

INJERA: SYMBOL OF IDENTITY, POWERHOUSE FOR HEALTH

Teff, Ethiopia's ancient staple grain, is a cornerstone of the country's culinary heritage, passed down through generations as the main ingredient in *injera*. Teff is highly valued for its exceptional nutritional profile: it is naturally gluten-free and is rich in fibre, iron, calcium and essential amino acids, making it one of the most nutrient-dense grains in the world.

The name teff comes from the Amharic word for "lost", because its small size historically made it hard to handle. However, its nutritional value and adaptability to harsh conditions have recently sparked global interest in the crop as a resilient, gluten-free superfood.

Teff (*Eragrostis teff*) can grow well in moisture-stressed and waterlogged conditions, better than other cereals. It is mainly cultivated in the central and northwest highland areas: the Central Ethiopia Regional State and the South Ethiopia Regional State; Amhara; and Tigray, in that order. Six-and-a-half million smallholder farmers grow teff, and it is indispensable to the livelihoods of many Ethiopians. Although the proportion may vary between individual farmers, generally 70 to 80 percent of the crops production is for farmers' own use, while the rest is sold.

In the Tigray region, 35-year-old Tsigie Yemane is an example of a woman farmer rebuilding her livelihood with new skills, confidence, and hope with the support of the FAO–Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) project, the "Project for Promoting Climate-Resilient Agricultural Management through the Establishment of Farmer Field Schools in Conflict Affected Communities in Tigray." Through the programme, Tsigie received improved Bosset teff seeds to establish a 0.25 hectare learning plot. Each week, she participated in farmer field school (FFS) training sessions that helped her to observe and analyse crop

performance, apply recommended practices and make informed, evidence-based decisions in all seasons. Tsigie was selected as one of the farmers to host a community field day, during which fellow FFS members, neighbouring farmers and development partners visited her plot to see the results firsthand. Standing proudly beside her neatly stacked teff, she explained how improved seed, guided decision-making, and the FFS approach transformed her farming practices and restored her confidence.

Today, Tsigie is recognized as a promising seed producer and an emerging leader among women farmers in Adwa Woreda. Her journey demonstrates the transformative impact of FFS-based interventions: empowering women to adopt improved practices, rebuild productive assets, strengthen household food security, and contribute to community recovery.

Her story is one of resilience, knowledge, and hope, made possible through the support of FAO, JICA and partners committed to restoring livelihoods in conflict-affected Tigray.

A woman farmer harvesting a teff crop in Ethiopia.

All photos: © FAO/Giulio Napolitano

ETHIOPIA

INJERA

FERMENTED TEFF FLATBREAD

Injera, a fermented flatbread made with teff, is Ethiopia's iconic staple food. More than a meal, it is a cultural tradition passed down through generations. Made primarily from teff flour, *injera* is a soft, spongy flatbread that serves as both plate and utensil in Ethiopian cuisine. Given teff's exceptional nutritional profile, *injera* is a powerhouse for health. The classic recipe for *injera* involves fermenting teff flour batter for 2–3 days to achieve its signature tangy flavour and airy texture.

Injera is more than food, as it is a symbol of Ethiopian identity that connects families and communities through shared meals and tradition.

© FAO/Eduardo Soteras

FOR **5–8 PIECES OF INJERA** YOU WILL NEED

- **2 cups** of teff flour (brown or ivory; brown is the more traditional version)
- **3 cups** of lukewarm water (adjust as needed)
- ***Absit*** (cooked teff paste – instructions below)
- **Pinch of** salt to taste (added only at the end)
- **2–3 tablespoons** of *ersho* (fermented liquid saved from previous *injera* batter, if available)

NOTES:
Ferment longer in cool climates (up to 4 days).
Use 100 percent teff (no wheat or barley).

If the *injera* does not bubble:
- Check if the batter is too thin. In this case, add teff flour.
- If the batter is too cold, move it to a warm room.
- If you skipped the *absit*, bubbles will not form.

Sourness control:
- If the *injera* is mild, cook it sooner.
- If it lacks the traditional sourness, ferment the batter longer.

Storage (traditional method)
- Stack the *injera* and wrap them in cloth.
- Store at room temperature for 1 day.
- Refrigerate for up to 3 days.
- *Injera* can be frozen for up to 1 month.

TERMINOLOGY

- ***Ersho*: fermented** starter culture, liquid
- ***Absit*: cooked** teff paste
- ***Mitad*: traditional** cooking pan; you can also use a good non-stick pan
- **When teff** is scarce, substitutes like sorghum, barley or a mix of wheat and teff can be used, though this slightly alters taste and nutrition.

3/4 DAYS TOTAL PREPARATION TIME

Prepare the batter and start fermentation

Mix the 2 cups of teff and 3 cups of lukewarm water in a large glass or clay bowl. Add a little *ersho* (if available). Whisk until smooth.

Use a clean tea towel to cover loosely and do not seal.

Leave at room temperature (20–25 °C / 68–77 °F) for 2–3 days.

Allow fermentation to happen

Ethiopian chefs look for bubbles forming and a slightly sour smell during fermentation. The mixture should separate into layers: liquid on top, and batter at the bottom. Do not stir during fermentation.

Baking

First drain of the excess water – pour off the thin water on the top, but not all of it.

Make the absit. This step is what gives *injera* its signature eyes (holes).

To make the *absit*, boil 1 cup of water in a small saucepan. Add ½ cup of the batter and mix into the boiling water, stirring continuously until it becomes a thick porridge with no lumps. Cook for 1–2 minutes on low heat until it becomes slightly thick and gelatinous, then let it cool slightly.

Add the warm (but not hot) *absit* to the fermented batter. Mix gently but thoroughly. Add a pinch of salt (optional). Cover and rest again for 30–60 minutes to activate bubbling again.

The batter should now be slightly thick but pourable; not too thick and not watery.

Cook the *injera* on a mitad or wide non-stick skillet on medium heat. Very lightly wipe pan with vegetable oil, just once.

Stir batter gently and pour batter in a spiral from outside to centre; the batter should spread to form a large thin circle. Cover immediately with a lid and cook for 1–2 minutes only. The *injera* is done when the surface is full of holes (“eyes”), the top is dry and the bottom is cooked but not too brown. Never flip *injera*. Remove the *injera* from the pan and place on a clean cloth or basket (*mesob*).

As a final step, taste salt, and if needed dissolve ½ tsp salt in 1 tbsp water and gently fold into the remaining batter.

Ghana

SMALL GRAIN, STRONG ROOTS: HOW FONIO BUILDS RESILIENCE FOR WOMEN

For Christabel Kwasi, a 29-year-old farmer and mother of three, fonio (*Digitaria exilis*) is both a crop and a source of confidence. Seeing her children enjoy the rich, nourishing porridge she prepares from the grain she grows is a reminder of what her work makes possible: healthy food on the table, and the satisfaction of knowing that her harvest helps sustain her family.

Fonio is an ancient indigenous West African cereal, and is traditionally cultivated by women farmers. In the Chereponi region of Northern Ghana, it is a staple food for farmers like Christabel. Once boiled, fonio resembles couscous. It can be consumed as such, or made into porridge. It can even be turned into flour for baking. It is a versatile crop that generations have relied on, for both food and livelihoods.

“I realized that my family likes fonio, and they depend on fonio more than any other food crop,” says Christabel. “Fonio is the type [of crop where] if you don’t even have money to buy chemicals [fertilizers], you can still farm it, feed on it.”

Until as recently as a year ago, Christabel thought she had to wait for periods of rainfall and rely on arduous traditional methods of cultivation to grow fonio, which often left her family with little to no harvest during the dry season.

However, a project recently implemented by FAO, in collaboration with Chef Fatmata Binta, renowned for bringing African gastronomy to the global scene, is giving Christabel and other farmers the knowledge needed to grow fonio year-round. Together with Ghana’s Ministry of Food and Agriculture, the project aims to support women fonio producers in Ghana to enhance their cultivation skills and boost productivity and income.

The good collaboration between FAO, Chef Binta and Ghana's Ministry of Food and Agriculture has shown how fonio is an effective resilience-building crop. Through training sessions on better production and post-harvest techniques, women fonio producers learned to increase their yields and properly store their grains to prevent food loss.

In Ghana, also the manual methods of post-harvest handling and processing – mostly undertaken by women – are exhausting processes impacting their yields. The methods require manually pounding the grains by hand for threshing, winnowing and then also manually drying. To minimize this time- and labour-intensive process, Chef Binta is providing processing machines, enabling women fonio producers to process their fonio achieving better quality and greater quantities.

Christabel has become one of the farmers that helps teach other women farmers.

Chereponi, North-East Region, Ghana. Christabel Kwasi, a woman farmer, inspects fonio plants in a fonio field.

All photos: © FAO/Fanjan Combrink

AZERBAIJAN GHANA

GROUNDNUT SOUP WITH FONIO

GREEN HERB QUTAB

Groundnut soup is a staple of the West African kitchen, that can be made with chicken, beef or smoked fish. This recipe was developed by Chef Binta as part of her ongoing work with the women fonio farmers, and the promotion of fonio as a mighty ancient grain feeding the future.

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TO FEED
4-6 PEOPLE
YOU WILL NEED

- **1 kg** chicken pieces, bone-in
- **1** large onion, peeled and quartered
- **2 tablespoons** tomato paste
- **150 g** natural groundnut (peanut) paste
- **2–3 whole** Scotch bonnet peppers
- **2** garden eggs (African eggplants), whole
- **2 tablespoons** dried okra powder
- **1.5 litres** water
- **Salt**, to taste

- **250 g** fonio
- **500 ml** water
- **½ tsp** salt

© FAO/Fanjan Combrink

Chereponi, North-East Region, Ghana. Chef Fatama Binta adds salt to the groundnut chicken stew cooking over an open fire, assisted by local women farmers.

PREPARATION

To prepare the groundnut soup, place the chicken, onion, garden eggs and Scotch bonnet peppers into a large saucepan. Add 1 litre of water and season lightly with salt.

Bring to a gentle boil, then reduce the heat and simmer for approximately 30 minutes, or until the chicken is tender and the vegetables are softened.

Remove the onion and garden eggs from the stock. Blend or mash until smooth, then return the mixture to the pot to enrich the soup's body and flavour.

Stir in the tomato paste and allow it to cook for 2–3 minutes.

In a separate bowl, loosen the groundnut paste with a little warm water, whisking until smooth. Gradually add this mixture to the soup, stirring continuously to prevent lumps from forming.

Add the dried okra and the remaining water. Simmer gently for a further 20–30 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the soup thickens and the characteristic groundnut oil begins to rise to the surface.

Taste and adjust with salt as required.

To cook the fonio, rinse it thoroughly under cold running water.

Bring the water and salt to a boil in a saucepan. Stir in the fonio, cover and reduce the heat to low.

Cook for 5 minutes, then remove from the heat and allow to steam, covered, for a further 5 minutes.

Fluff gently with a fork before serving.

To serve, ladle the hot groundnut soup into warmed bowls, ensuring each portion contains generous pieces of chicken. Serve alongside the steamed fonio, allowing guests to enjoy the rich, nutty broth with the light, delicate grains.

Chereponi, North-East Region, Ghana. Women farmers wash their hands before sitting down to eat groundnut stew with fonio porridge outdoors, prepared by Chef Fatama Binta. (Top)

Women farmers enjoying a groundnut stew with fonio porridge prepared with the help from Chef Fatama Binta. (Bottom)

QUTAB

Chereponi, North-East Region, Ghana. A groundnut chicken stew, served alongside a stiff fonio porridge. (Right)

GREEN HERB QUTAB

All photos: © FAO/Fanjan Combrink

Jordan

CULTIVATING KNOWLEDGE, HARVESTING TRADITION: WOMEN AND THE FUTURE OF OLIVE OIL

Feryal Al-Kofahi began her story as a small-scale farmer, cultivating olive trees, among other crops. After joining the Jordanian Women's Olive Oil Network, she participated in many training programmes and workshops focused on good agricultural practices. These interventions led to a significant increase in her olive and olive oil productivity and a marked improvement in quality.

The olive (*Olea europaea*) is a shrub tree native to the Mediterranean Basin, of which the first historical records date back to the sixth century BCE. The olive tree is believed to have originated in what are today known as the Syrian Arab Republic, Palestine, Lebanon and Jordan; from here, it spread to the rest of the world.

Jordan is home to some of the world's oldest olive trees, as revealed by excavations in the Wadi Rum area, in the valley of Sabt: carbon analysis of charred wood indicate that the region has been growing olives since 5400 BCE.

Beyond farming, Feryal has excelled in the culinary arts. Through her participation in various local and international festivals and exhibitions – including the cooking show at the launch of the International Year of the Woman Farmer 2026 – she has represented her cuisine, community and country internationally and showcased her skills, particularly in traditional dishes using extra virgin olive oil.

Feryal has also become a trainer, becoming a mentor for other women producers. Her story is one of resilience, transformation and a deep-rooted passion for her community's heritage.

JORDAN

© Reham Ahmad Qasam Dahadha

© Alex Blokstra/Pexels

Feryal tosses freshly harvested olives.

JORDAN

MAKMOURA WITH CHICKEN

Originating from the north of Jordan, *makmoura*, meaning buried, is exactly what it sounds like: chicken and onions are finely chopped and buried between layers of dough, then placed in the oven until fully cooked. It is later cut into triangle pieces and served like pie. The highest-quality olive oil possible should be used when making this recipe. The best time to prepare it is just after the olive harvest, when olive oil is at its freshest and most abundant.

© Reham Ahmad Qasam Dahadha

TO FEED
4-6 PEOPLE
YOU WILL NEED

- **1 whole** large chicken
- **600 g** onions, finely sliced
- **2 cups** extra virgin olive oil
- **800 g** wheat flour
- **1 tablespoon** sesame seeds and **1 tablespoon** black nigella seeds
- **Salt and** pepper, desired

PREPARATION

First, prepare the filling. In a pot, begin by sautéing the chicken with the chopped onions and a generous pour of extra virgin olive oil.

Add the salt and pepper, mixing well to combine the flavours. Let the mixture cook on the heat for about half an hour to allow the flavours to mingle. Add a little water if necessary. Let the mixture cool a little. Remove all bones and shred the chicken. Adjust salt and pepper.

While the chicken is cooking, prepare the dough. In a separate bowl, mix the flour with the salt, sesame seeds and nigella seeds. Gradually add water to form a consistent dough, then let it rest covered for 10–15 minutes.

Next, assemble the *makmoura* on a round baking dish. Divide the rested dough into small pieces suitable for your cooking dish. Roll out the first layer of dough to the size of the pan, then add a layer of the prepared chicken, onions and olive oil.

Repeat the layering process until all the dough and filling are used. Drizzle well with olive oil.

Place the dish in the oven at medium heat (approximately 180 °C) and bake for about 2.5–3 hours until the dough and chicken are thoroughly cooked. Many cooks cover the *makmoura* for the first half of the cooking process, then remove the covering to let the pastry crisp up in the final stage.

Let the pie rest for a few minutes before cutting and serving in triangular pieces.

© Reham Ahmad Qasam Dahadha

Madagascar

BEAN BY BEAN: FARMER FIELD SCHOOLS SOW NUTRITION AND HOPE

In rural Madagascar, a network of farmer field schools help strengthen women's ability to produce nutrient-rich foods, adopt better feeding habits, and prevent acute malnutrition in their children.

The Miraihina Farmer Field School in Ambahatrazo brings together 21 women from the Antemoro community around a common goal: to improve their agricultural production systems while sustainably strengthening the nutritional quality of their households.

Henicia is the leader of the group of women involved in the programme, which provides training in home gardening, small livestock production, climate-smart practices and more. The women also learn to prepare balanced meals using local ingredients and the highly nutritious crops promoted through the project. These changes are contributing to healthier household diets and improved childhood feeding practices, demonstrating strong potential to reduce acute malnutrition in the community.

One of the key crops grown by the women farmers are Cal98 beans (the common bean, *Phaseolus vulgaris*), known locally as *fofifa vanbamena*. The beans, which have high iron and zinc content, are well-suited to local conditions when cultivated using controlled farming practices, and offer significant and relatively stable yield potential. Their high plant protein content is a key advantage in a context where access to animal protein remains limited for many households.

Mothers and children sort freshly harvested Cal98 beans, a nutrient-rich crop grown by the Miraihina Farmer Field School in Madagascar.

All photos: © Rombaka, Solondrainy

MADAGASCAR

SOUPE DE MANIOC AUX LÉGUMES

MANIOCA AND BEAN SOUP

Madagascan manioca and bean soup combines cassava, Cal98 beans and moringa leaves – simple yet nutritious local ingredients. Carrots, tomatoes and onions bring colour and flavour, while garlic adds a kick. Simmered slowly, it is served hot and constitutes a complete meal, representative of traditional Madagascan cuisine. This soup is a simple soup that can be consumed daily, full of nutrition for children and adults alike.

© Rombaka, Solondrainy

All photos: © Rombaka, Solondrainy

Rows of young bean plants grow in a field in Madagascar.

TO FEED **3-4 PEOPLE** YOU WILL NEED

- **400 g** medium-sized fresh cassava roots
- **150 g** dried Cal98 beans (250 g cooked)
- **1 large** onion, diced
- **1 to** 2 tablespoons of oil
- **2 cloves** of garlic, peeled and minced
- **2 large** carrots, peeled and diced
- **2 tomatoes,** roughly chopped
- **1 handful** of fresh or dried moringa leaves, washed and pulled of stems
- **Salt (to** taste)

PREPARATION

Soak the dried beans in water for roughly 4 hours before cooking to reduce cooking time and improve digestibility.

Put beans in a pot with cold water and cook until tender.

Peel the cassava, cut it into small cubes, and wash them thoroughly. Add to a medium pot of boiling water and cook for 2–3 minutes. Discard the cooking water.

Return the pot with the cassava to the heat, cover with cold water and cook until just able to be pierced with a skewer.

Meanwhile, dice the onion and garlic. Cut the carrots and tomatoes into pieces.

In a large pot, sauté the onion and garlic in a little oil with a pinch of salt. Add the tomatoes and carrots and cook for a few minutes, until slightly reduced.

Add the cassava and cooked beans (with their water). Add another 1 litre of water.

Simmer until the cassava and beans are tender, adding spoons of water if necessary. Add the moringa right at the very end of cooking. Do not cook the moringa for more than 1 minute in order to preserve the nutrients.

Remove from heat and serve hot. Adjust salt to taste.

Niger

MORINGA: A PLANT VALUED FOR ITS LEAVES, PODS AND SEEDS

Moringa *(Moringa oleifera)* is a cash crop in the Niger, consumed daily as a leafy vegetable in rural and urban areas. The main production areas are in Maradi, Tillabéry, Dosso, Tahoua and Niamey. An important crop for nutritional security, it was introduced to the Niger in the early twentieth century. Moringa leaves are rich in protein and calories.

Women mainly ensure the retail sale of moringa in markets. They are practically absent from wholesale trade but also from cultivation, because they often cannot own land (due to customary laws), especially to cultivate a plant that can remain unproductive for more than 15 years and is similar to a perennial crop. However, particularly in the Maradi region, part of the moringa is processed by women. They buy fresh leaves from producers and pre-cook and dry them, before selling the processed product to traders who collect, repackage and resell the dried leaves. As with many foods, proper preparation is necessary to avoid losing too many nutrients, especially vitamins destroyed by the heat of cooking. Also, the leaves should be consumed quickly after harvesting and cooked for only a short time. It is important to conserve and use the liquid in which they are cooked, which also has nutritional value. Moringa leaves are an economical source of protein, vitamins and minerals.

Consumed as a national dish, several moringa-based recipes are produced during traditional ceremonies. Sixty percent of Nigeriens consume moringa daily, and demand is influenced by daily habits and festive periods. Recently, local hotel and restaurant chains have started incorporating moringa into their menus.

Mme Djibrilla Nafissatou Sahirou, a moringa processor, harvests moringa leaves in her garden in Niamey, Niger.

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© FAO/Agali Moumouni

NIGER

DAMBOU WITH MORINGA

Dambou is an emblematic dish from the Niger, traditionally made with moringa and millet semolina, although these days rice semolina is more commonly used. In the Niger, when we talk about *dambou*, we refer to the Djerma, an ethnic group concentrated in the Dosso and Tillabéry region, where this recipe is very typical.

Dambou has become a national dish, consumed daily either for breakfast or more frequently for lunch. However, it is also commonly found at wedding and baptism ceremonies. It often accompanies a meat dish such as *gabagaba*, a recipe based on pounded chicken and peanuts.

© Alice Adams Carosi

TO FEED
3-4 PEOPLE
YOU WILL NEED

- **250 grams** rice semolina
- **500 ml** lukewarm water
- **120 ml** vegetable oil
- **2 teaspoons** salt (more or less according to taste)
- **3 handfuls** cooked moringa (the quantity can be increased as you wish)
- **½ onion,** sliced
- **1 large** onion, chopped
- **3 green** chilis (optional)
- **100 ml** oil for frying the onion (preferably peanut oil)
- **3 pinches** salt
- **1 bouillon** cube (optional)
- **Seasoned dry** chili, ready to eat (as desired)

NOTES: Rice semolina can be replaced by any type of cereal semolina (wheat, corn, millet). Corn and rice semolina are more frequently used to make this recipe. Moringa can be mixed with spinach, white sorrel flowers (*waraou*) or purslane (*youla youla*).

PREPARATION

To cook the moringa, remove the leaves from the stems and discard the stems. Wash the green leaves in clean water.

Bring a medium pot of water to the boil and cook the leaves for 5–10 minutes with a pinch of salt. Drain the leaves and set aside.

To cook the rice semolina, put water in a pot, place the couscous cooker on top, and bring to the heat.

Pour the semolina into a salad bowl and add 125 ml of water. Stir well with a fork to avoid lumps, and let it rest for 5 minutes. Add 30 ml of oil and stir well, crushing the lumps. Spread a clean cloth at the bottom of the couscous cooker before putting the semolina to cook for 15 minutes.

Using the skimmer, remove the semolina from the couscous cooker and pour it into the salad bowl. Spread the pre-cooked grains well; then sprinkle with 125 ml of water and with 2 teaspoons of salt, stir well and spread with the skimmer or fork. Let it rest for 5 minutes before putting it back to cook for 20 minutes.

Repeat this step 1 to 2 times until you are sure that the semolina is well cooked and tender. Each time you put it back to cook, sprinkle with a little water, in a quantity less than the previous steps. Adjust the salt to taste.

Pour the cooked rice semolina into the salad bowl. Drain the moringa well, and squeeze well to extract the remaining water. Mix with the semolina. Add a quarter of the onion, sliced; mix well and steam again for 10 minutes. Pour the mixture into the salad bowl and set aside.

To complete the *dambou*, in a small saucepan, sauté the remaining onion in 100 ml of oil until golden brown. Add the crushed or minced green chili, salt and (optionally) the bouillon cube. Simmer until the mixture is fried and the condiment is ready.

Arrange a dish in which the *dambou* is arranged and sprinkled with the fried onion and chili. The dish is ready to eat.

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